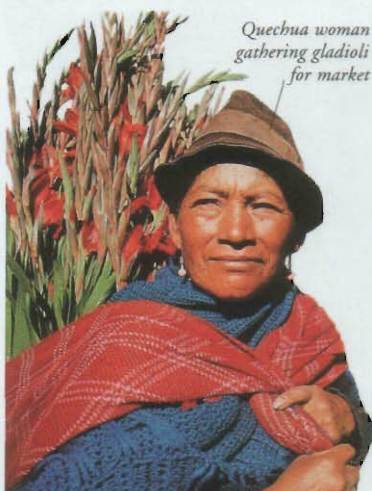
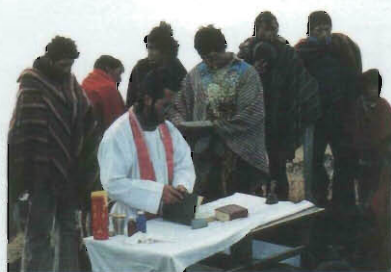


Ecuador

 The third smallest, most densely populated independent country in South America, Ecuador is also one of the most geographically varied and politically stable. Agriculture and oil dominate the economy. About 1,000 km (630 miles) off Ecuador's Pacific coast, the lonely Galápagos Islands, famous for their unique wildlife, are part of the country.



Quechua woman gathering gladioli for market



Oil

Since the 1970s, oil, piped from the eastern lowlands, has been the mainstay of Ecuador's economy and accounts for 40 per cent of exports. Other exports are balsa wood, shrimps, processed fish, and textiles. Most goods are exported via Guayaquil, Ecuador's main port and largest city.

Crops

Beans, maize, and potatoes are the main crops grown in the Andes. Bananas, cocoa beans, rice, coffee, oranges, and wheat are cultivated on the coast, mostly for export. Roses, carnations, gladioli, and statice (sea lavender) are grown for markets.

People

Native Americans make up 25 per cent and *mestizos* more than 50 per cent of the population. The rest of the people are white, black, or Asian. More than 93 per cent of the people are Roman Catholic, although some people blend Catholicism with traditional beliefs.

ECUADOR FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Quito
AREA	283,560 sq km (109,483 sq miles)
POPULATION	12,500,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Spanish, Quechua
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	US dollar

Otavaló market

The small town of Otavaló lies high in the Andes, north of the capital Quito. Local Indians weave brightly coloured ponchos and rugs to sell at the famous Otavaló market, which dates from pre-Inca times.



Panama hats

Originally made in the 1800s in Ecuador, to protect the heads of travellers, panama hats are constructed from the fibres of the toquilla plant. A panama can be rolled up for packing – a good one will pass through a finger ring.



Bold rug designs, often with an animal theme, are woven from homespun wool fibre.

Peru

 Four hundred years ago, Peru was at the heart of the Inca Empire, ruins of which still survive high in the Andes. The country has great mineral resources, yet most Peruvians are poor farmers, growing potatoes, maize, rice, and cereals for their own use, and cotton and coffee for export. Political terrorism by the Maoist Shining Path group has forced military rule in some areas.



Railways

Peru has two unconnected railway networks – the Central and Southern Railroads – both of which go from the coast to the highlands. A branch of the Central Railroad linking Lima and Huancayo in the Andes reaches 4,818 m (15,806 ft) above sea-level, making it the highest standard-gauge line in the world.

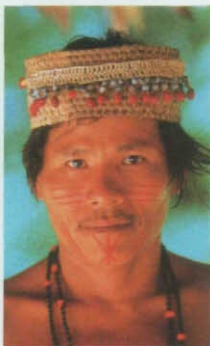


Machu Picchu

Peru's greatest tourist attraction is the ruined Inca city of Machu Picchu in the Andes. The ruins, hidden by dense forest vegetation, were discovered in 1911, when American archaeologist Hiram Bingham stumbled upon them, almost by accident. The ruins are made of stone and were built without mortar.

People

About half of Peruvians are Native American, and one-third are *mestizo*. The most populated areas are the highlands and the coastal plain. Only five per cent of people live in the remote Amazon Basin areas, including 70 Native American groups.



Jivaro man

Fishing

The cold waters of the Peru coastal current bring rich nutrients that attract large numbers of pilchards, sardines, tuna, and other fish, making fishing a major industry in Peru. However, every few years, the arrival of the El Niño current raises the temperature of the water driving away the fish and causing great hardship to the fishermen.



Sardines

Mining

Peru is a leading producer of copper, lead, tungsten, silver, and zinc and has reserves of gold, iron ore, and oil. However, low world mineral prices and industrial problems have badly affected mining.

Opencast lead mine in the Andes



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